

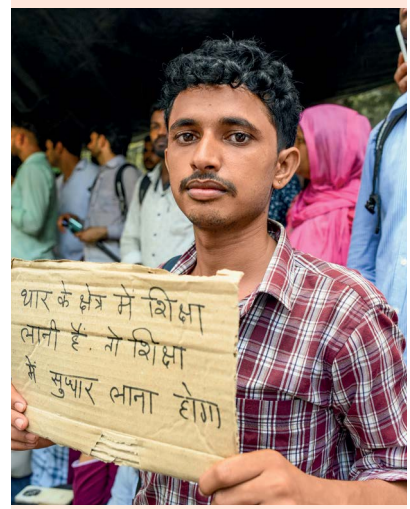
cent by late 2024. Among dropouts, the proportion citing the need to support household incomes rose sharply, from 58 per cent to 72 per cent.

"Jobs are the lens through which young people see the world because it's about their future," says Sabina Dewan, founder of research firm JustJobs Network. "In that sense, this entire protest is really about jobs and livelihoods, and the deep insecurity the young have." Labour force participation is a serious problem as only 46 per cent of 15- to 29-year-olds are either working or looking for work. The Periodic Labour Force Survey 2025 puts unemployment among youth at 9.9 per cent, three times the overall unemployment rate of 3.1 per cent. Nearly one in four young Indians is not in education, employment or training. The government, on its part, cites additions in EPFO (Employees' Provident Fund Organisation) and NPS (National Pension System) payrolls, Mudra loans, PLI (production-linked incentive) schemes generated 1.45 million jobs and over 300 million e-Shram registrations and disputes the methodologies used by the CMIE (Centre for Monitoring Indian Economy) and ILO (International Labour Organization).

VOX POP

"AN UNEQUAL EDUCATION"

MAHAVIR SIYOL | 22
SSC aspirant, Jodhpur, Rajasthan



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

My friends have already seen their competitive exams disrupted by paper leaks and cancelled tests. But I'm even more worried about the children of the Thar. Many primary and upper primary government schools in the region have shut down. We need more government schools, not fewer, if we are to bridge the inequalities in India's education system.

THE JOBS CRISIS

But the fact remains that unemployment is nearly 40 per cent among graduates aged 15-25, the highest for any educational category. Between 2004 and 2023, the number of graduates increased by nearly five million a year on average, but graduate employment rose by only 2.8 million a year and salaried graduate employment by 1.7 million, according to the 'State of Working India 2026' report by Azim Premji University. Close to 90 per cent of workers remain in informal employment. "More Indians are educated than ever before and yet they can't find jobs, while employers say they can't find skilled employees," says Amit Basole of Azim Premji University, co-author of the report. For educated young people in smaller cities, the scarcity of stable salaried work makes government jobs disproportionately attractive, intensifying competition and feeding the coaching economy. When an examination collapses, the state blocks not just access to a job, but what for many is the only credible path to upward mobility.

The government cannot be accused of lacking proposals. The National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 promised multidisciplinary universities, four-year undergraduate degrees with multiple entry and exit options, credit portability, a single regulator through the Higher Education Commission of India (HECI), the Anusandhan National Research Foundation, foreign university campuses, digital universities and education expenditure equivalent to six per cent of GDP. On paper, it is the most extensive restructuring of education in decades. In practice, it is marred by the familiar blight of uneven implementation. Roughly 56 per cent of universities had introduced the four-year programme, 49 per cent multiple entry and exit, 41 per cent internship cells and